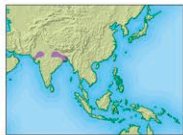


Platanista gangetica

Ganges river dolphin



Location S. Asia (Indus and Ganges-Brahmaputra river systems)



Length 5½–8½ ft (1.7–2.6 m)

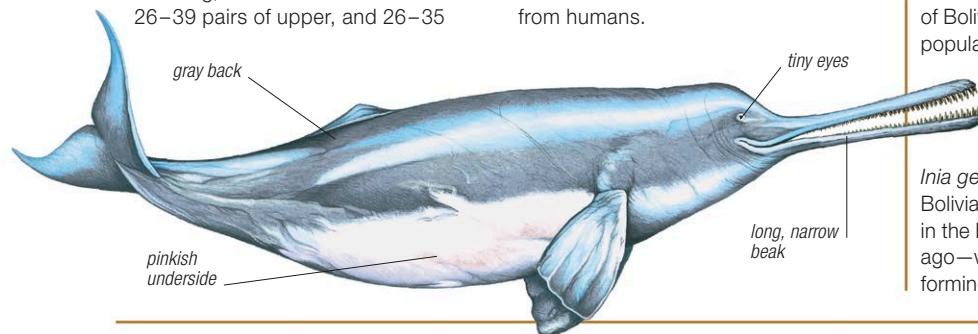
Weight About 242 lb (110 kg)

Social unit Variable

Status Endangered

Also known by the local names susu and bhulan, this exclusively freshwater species has distinctively broad flippers and a long, narrow beak armed with 26–39 pairs of upper, and 26–35

pairs of lower, sharp teeth. The front teeth extend outside the beak's tip, to form a catching cage for fish, shellfish, and similar prey on or near the bottom. The flexible neck allows the head to bend at right angles as the dolphin grubs in the mud or "scans" the area with echolocating sound pulses. The Ganges river dolphin lives in small groups, usually 4–6 but occasionally up to 30. However, its social life and breeding habits are largely unknown. There are 2 subspecies: *Platanista gangetica minor* in the Indus river and its tributaries, and *Platanista gangetica gangetica* in the Ganges-Brahmaputra river system. Both are extremely rare and face numerous threats from humans.

*Inia boliviensis*

Bolivian boto



Location C. South America



Length 9¼ ft (2.8 m)

Weight 396 lb (180 kg)

Social unit Individual/Pair

Status Not evaluated

Once recognized as a smaller, gray subspecies of the pink Amazon river dolphin, this dolphin is now considered to be a distinct species. It is found in the Beni, Mamoré, and Guaporé rivers of Bolivia—and isolated from other *Inia* populations by 240 miles (400 km) of falls in the Madeira river. Various studies have demonstrated that it is genetically distinct from its more widespread cousin *Inia geoffrensis*. They also indicate that Bolivian boto probably became isolated in the Beni region about 5 million years ago—when Andean mountains were forming and before Madeira's



waterfalls arose. Like the Amazon river dolphin, the Bolivian boto preys on bottom-dwelling fishes while swimming, which it snatches using a long beak—helped by a flexible neck. It is more abundant in lagoons and confluences, where prey becomes concentrated by eddies and whirlpools and so is more easily trapped. These dolphins usually travel alone or in pairs. They are less likely to be seen during high water season, perhaps because they then can disperse into flooded forest.

Inia geoffrensis

Amazon river dolphin



Location South America (Amazon and Orinoco basins)



Length 6–8¼ ft (1.8–2.5 m)

Weight 154–455 lb (70–207 kg)

Social unit Variable

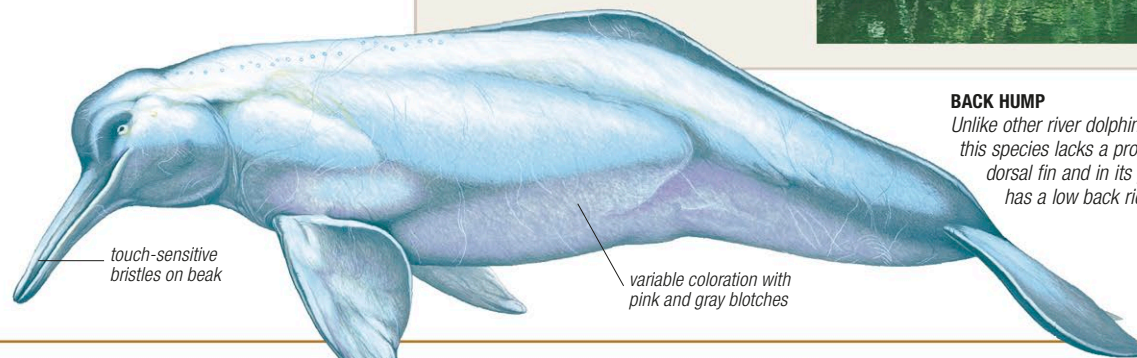
Status Data deficient

Also called the pink river dolphin or bufeo, this species ranges through the Amazon and Orinoco river systems. It possesses a long, slim beak and flexible neck, for poking in mud for prey during short dives of 1–2 minutes. Being small-eyed and living in murky water, it probably finds its way and food mainly

by echolocating sound pulses. The Amazon river dolphin has 25–35 pairs of teeth in both upper and lower jaws. At the front, the teeth are peglike, for seizing prey, but at the rear, they are flatter with peaks or cusps, and thus suited to crushing freshwater crabs, river turtles, and armored catfish. The single calf, 32 in (80 cm) long, is born between May and July.

CAUTIOUS APPROACH

Known for its slow, apparently lethargic lifestyle, the Amazon river dolphin usually lives alone or in twos, occasionally in groups of up to 20. In some areas, it may approach boats or swimmers out of curiosity, but in regions where it is hunted, it has become more cautious.



BACK HUMP

Unlike other river dolphins, this species lacks a proper dorsal fin and in its place has a low back ridge.

Delphinapterus leucas

Beluga



Location Arctic Ocean



Length 10–14¼ ft (3–4.5 m)

Weight ¼–1½ tons (0.5–1.6 tonnes)

Social unit Group

Status Near threatened

The beluga, or white whale, keeps mainly to the edges of the Arctic ice-fields and has been radio-tracked diving to 985 ft (300 m), presumably navigating by echolocation to find prey and breathing holes. This vocal whale emits varied calls, including squeaks, whistles, mews, clicks, and hums. These are audible through the hulls of boats, giving the beluga its nickname of sea canary. The outgoing echolocation sounds are focused by

the bulging melon. The beluga feeds on fish, mollusks, crustaceans, and other prey, which it crushes with its 8–11 pairs of teeth both the upper and lower jaws. The calf is dark gray and 5 ft (1.5 m) long at birth. It is paler by 2 years old, and blue-tinged white by the age of 5.

ALL-WHITE WHALE

The only all-white cetacean, the adult beluga blends with the Arctic ice floes and icebergs. Its skin may be tinged yellow before the summer molt.



CONSERVATION

As global warming opens up Arctic sea routes, belugas are increasingly threatened by pollution from shipping and oil exploration, as seen at the St. Lawrence estuary. Belugas are also targeted by subsistence hunters, but commercial hunting is banned by conservation treaties.

